

Microsoft, like the competition, has spent years trying to match Apple in the smartphone market. It developed new versions of Windows Mobile to no avail, and lost market share over the next three years. It developed, but never released, a Windows Mobile 7 product that would have basically copied the iPhone design, morphing it on top of the old Windows Mobile foundation that, quite frankly, hadn't changed appreciably since that very first version of Windows CE. One thing was clear: If Microsoft continued down this path, Windows Mobile would have been driven into the ground by RIM in the business market and by Apple in the consumer market. It's at moments like this that companies typically do one of two things. They can fail to see what's happening and become slowly more irrelevant over time. Or they can simply start over.

A new beginning: Windows Phone 7

In 2009, examining both the marketplace and the work it had done toward a new version of Windows Mobile, Microsoft hit the reset button. It jettisoned years of work, over a decade of technological history, and simply decided to start over from scratch. Well, not entirely from scratch. As it turns out, other groups within Microsoft had been laying the groundwork for what would become the company's next generation phone platform. This work started with a project called "Freestyle", which became Windows Media Center, a TV-friendly interface for digital media. Aside from some obvious graphical niceties and functional excellence, the big deal with Media Center, in retrospect, was that it pushed Microsoft to start thinking about non-traditional PC interaction, in this case a TV-based remote control.

As Media Center evolved over the lifetimes of Windows XP, Vista and then 7, it was adapted to work with other non-traditional interfaces, including the pen/stylus interface from Tablet PCs, and, later, touch and multi-touch. By the time Windows 7 appeared, Media Center had evolved to



The all new Windows Phones